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CHALLENGES AHEAD

- **Rafale is here, but IAF squadron strength down to 30 against the sanctioned 42**
- **Position of CDS still vacant since death of Gen. Bipin Rawat**
- **There is no consensus within the three forces on joint theatre commands**
- **Resistance even after Supreme Court cleared the decks for women to get permanent commission and command roles**

the twin challenge of an aggressive China and a raging pandemic was unprecedented. It could not have been war-gamed.

However, the brief clashes, the eyeball-to-eyeball confrontation and the near-stasis—despite 15 rounds of talks—ever since in Ladakh have given impetus to the push for self-reliance in defence along the lines of the government's mantra of *aatmanirbharta*. Among various defence projects aimed at boosting domestic manufacturing, the indigenous aircraft carrier *Vikrant* is the prominent big-ticket platform. The ship completed its maiden sea voyage in August 2021 and will be commissioned by August 15 this year.

The thrust on self-reliance has been complemented with decisions like the ministry of defence barring imports of 310 defence platforms and weapon systems, beginning from August 2020. In addition, the ministry's ban on the import of 2,851 items that were being procured from abroad will save up to Rs 3,000 crore each year, according to its estimates. The purpose of the embargo on defence imports is, of course, aimed at strengthening domestic manufacturing. The new defence policy aims at Rs 35,000 crore defence exports in five years (2025) and doubling domestic procurement worth Rs 1.4 lakh crore of equipment.

With self-reliance being the refrain, the defence budget for 2022-23 has earmarked 25 per cent of research and development expenditure exclusively for Indian companies, start-ups and academia. However, the key strategic partnership model aimed at bolstering domestic manufacturing of defence equipment in joint ventures with foreign players faces hurdles. The projects under the model included helicopters, submarines, fighter aircraft and tanks, but negotiations over transfer of technology are dragging on for over five years since the plan was announced. ■